FROM AI USERS TO AI BUILDERS: LEADING MARKETING TEAMS INTO THE NEXT PHASE



DAN SLAGEN

CMO & CAITO

Zapier

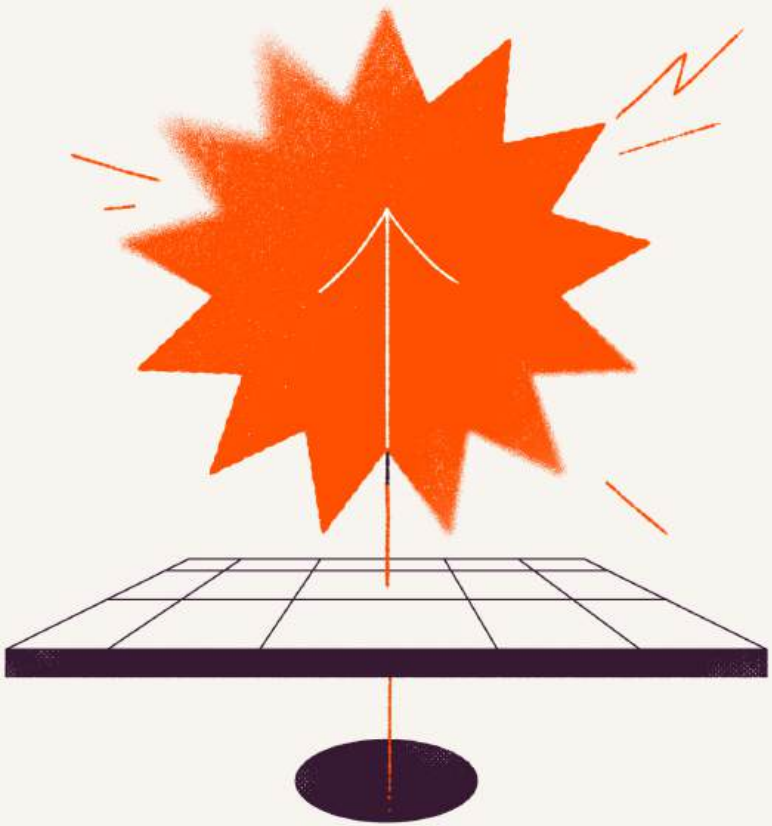
MAICON FORWARD

#MAICON26

Don't wait for the Red Alert

How Zapier's marketing team refounded itself

Dan Slagen · CMO & Chief AI Transformation Officer, Zapier



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INTRO

Let's clear up a few things on AI

01

Not behind

You're not behind.

02

Focus ≠ impact

So much focus on AI vs. little impact.

03

Operations

Radical operational change is #1.

04

People

You have to make people decisions now.

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THE AGENTIC ERA

Welcome to automation in the agentic era

ZAPIER

Employee AI adoption

99%

ZAPIER

Apps on the platform

9,000+



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THE AGENTIC ERA

We beat the first level of AI!

Faster creation

Better prompts

Personal productivity

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THE AGENTIC ERA

But the results aren't showing up...

ADOPTION

of companies use AI

88%

IMPACT

see EBIT impact

6%

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FOUR PHASES

Four phases

01 · ENTRY: LOW

Creation

02 · ENTRY: MEDIUM

Roles & functions

Systematic AI — HeyGen, 11x, Deep Research

03 · ENTRY: HIGH

Dev tools

Shared brain — Codex, Claude Code, Cursor

04 · ENTRY: HIGHER

Agentic systems

The agentic org

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THE PROBLEM

The 4-phase AI problem

Chasms getting larger



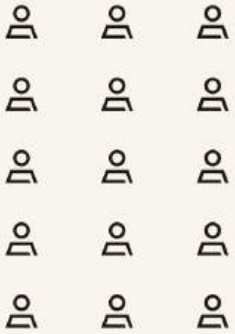
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THE CHASM

Scared or motivated?

1

Creation





YOU, not technology will get you across this chasm

4

Agentic systems



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SECTION 01

The 2026 Transformation



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JANUARY 2026

January 1

A normal, ahead-of-the-curve marketing team on AI.

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TALENT DEPTH

Talent depth

Jan 1 — a normal, ahead-of-the-curve marketing team on AI



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TALENT DEPTH

Talent depth changed overnight



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TALENT DEPTH

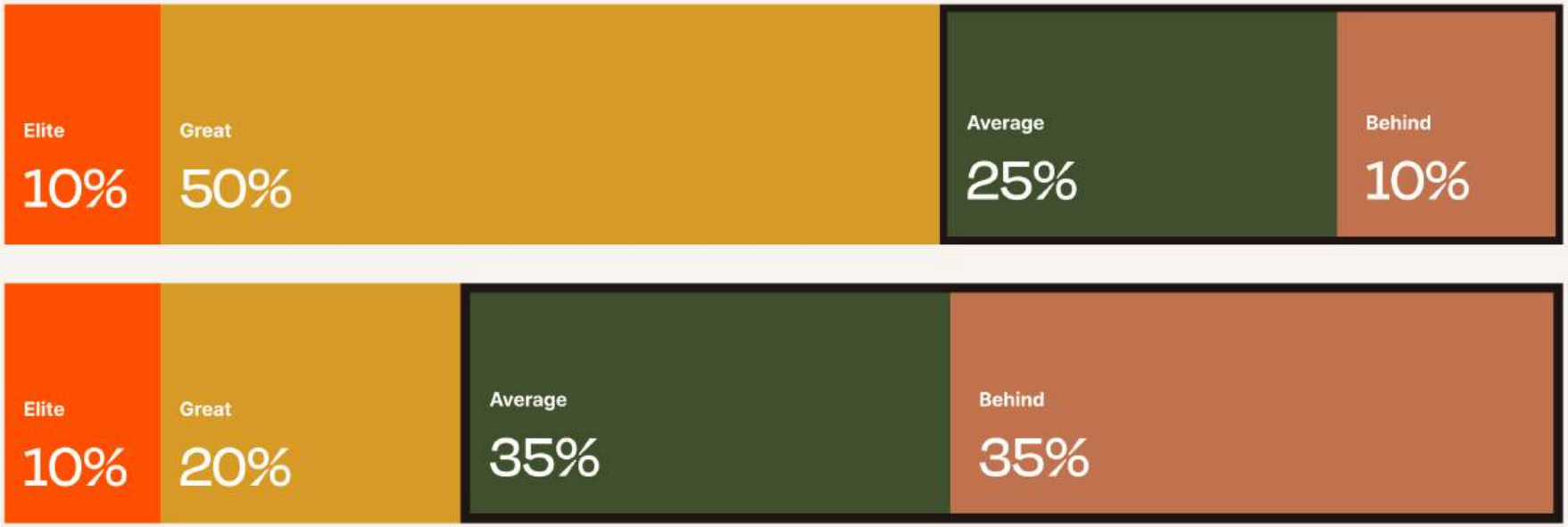
Talent depth changed overnight



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TALENT DEPTH

Talent depth changed overnight



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F1 DRIVERS

What I heard then. Hear same now.

"Fear, stopping exploration"

"This is how we work"

"The craft"

"I don't like this"

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F1 DRIVERS

F1 drivers: own your outcome

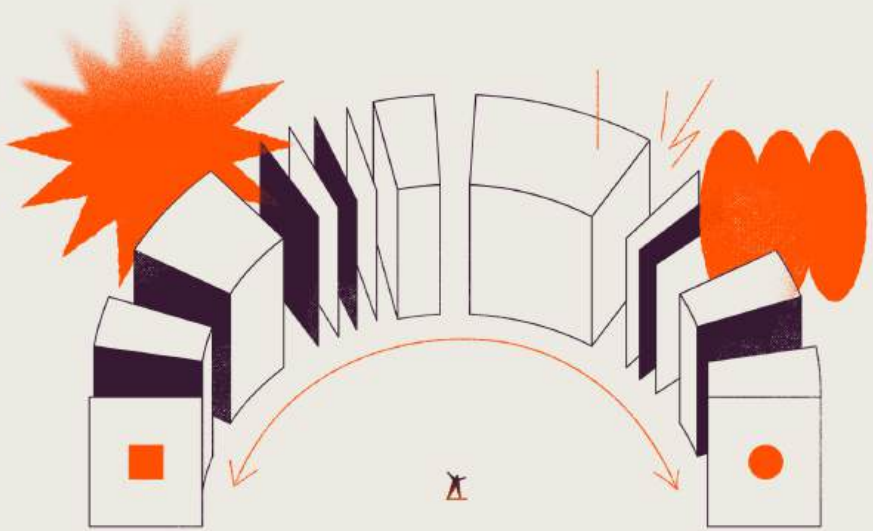
Act →	"Fear, stopping exploration"
Uncomfortable →	"This is how we work"
Progress →	"The craft"
Change →	"I don't like this"

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SECTION 02

Red Alert

February 2026



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RED ALERT

Once upon a time in...



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“You didn’t know this person existed, you don’t know who you’re interviewing against.”

RED ALERT

Build-a-thon prep

TIME

weeks to learn

3

TOOL

tool, your choice

1

Cursor, Codex, or Claude Code

SUPPORT

peer coaches

5

Already on the team

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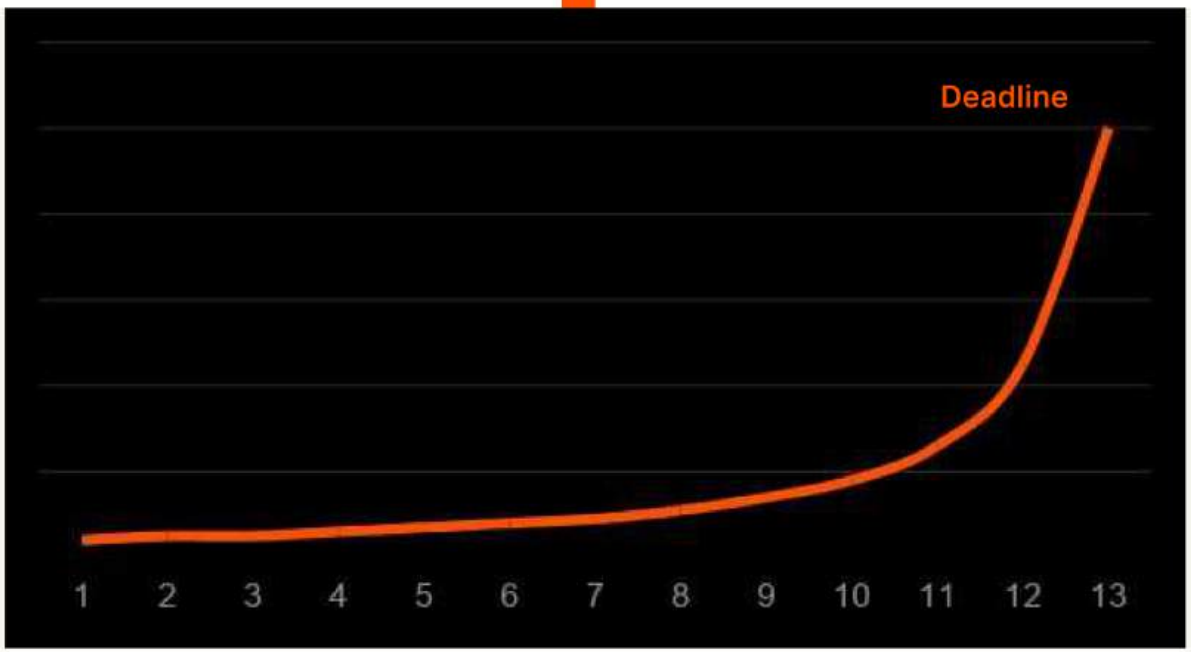
BUILD-A-THON

Critical: I built as well

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BUILD-A-THON

Token usage



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BUILD-A-THON

The builds

60+

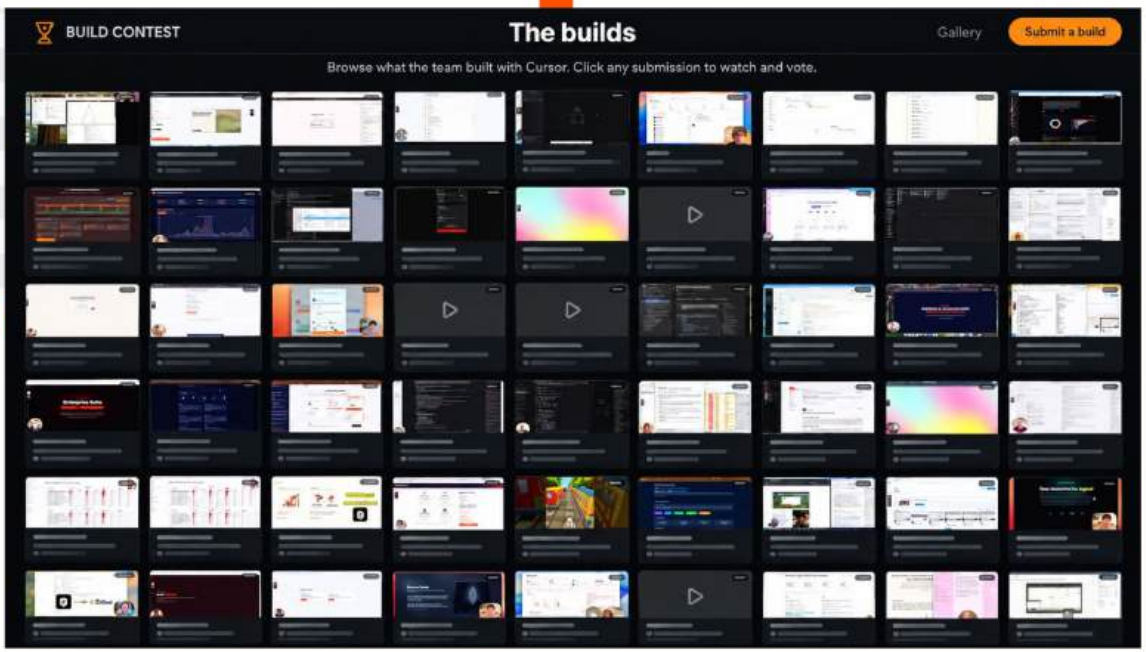
builds

9

themes

3

tiers



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RED ALERT

What people said

~~"I'm overwhelmed and scared."~~

"I'm on a journey
I'm excited about,
and I appreciate you're
here with me."

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RED ALERT #2

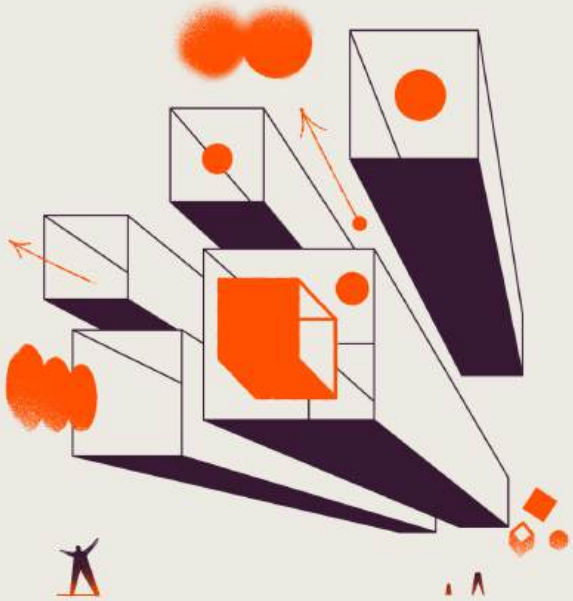
Another red alert, now

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SECTION 03

Individual AI → institutional AI

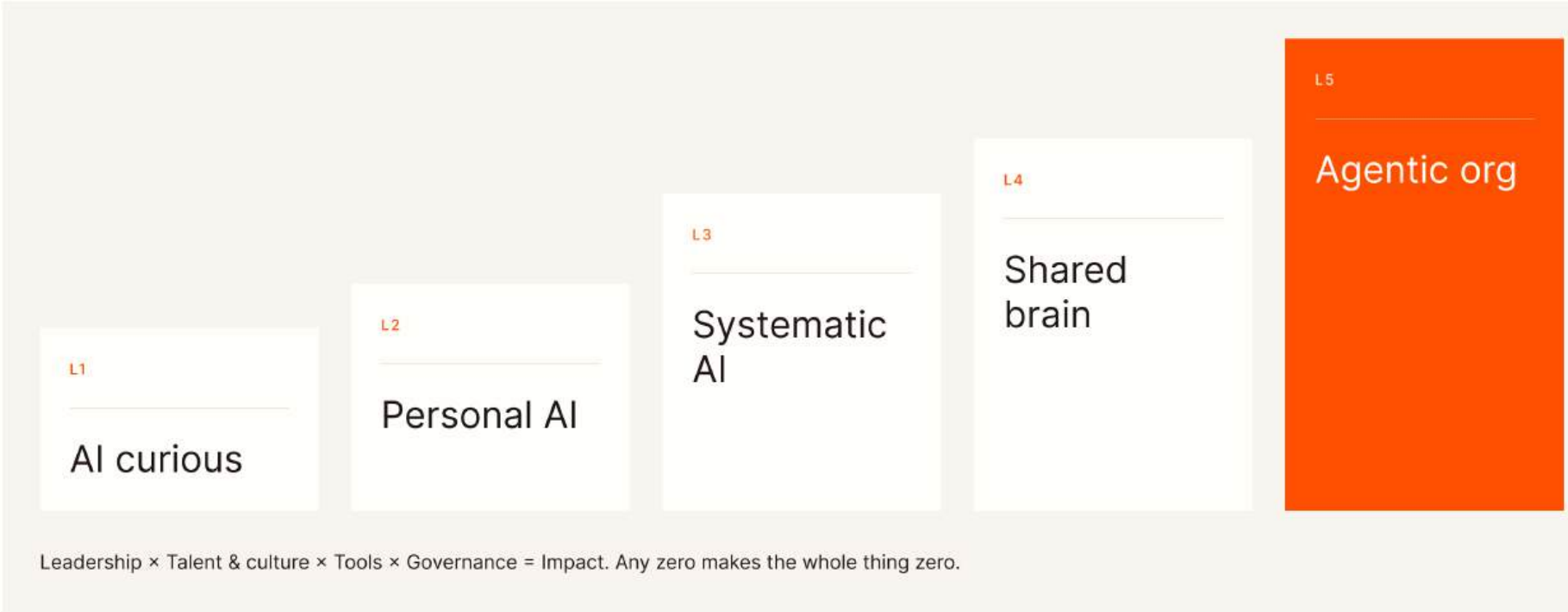
10x individual is easy. 10x company is harder.



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THE LADDER

The ladder



Leadership × Talent & culture × Tools × Governance = Impact. Any zero makes the whole thing zero.

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MARKETINGOS

Shared brain & single version of truth

01

Signals, always on

→ Gong calls
→ Competitive intel
→ Social listening
→ Deal outcomes
→ Site & pipeline data

02

Canonical context

→ 6 documents
→ 1 named owner each
→ Agents propose
→ Humans promote
→ Positioning council

03

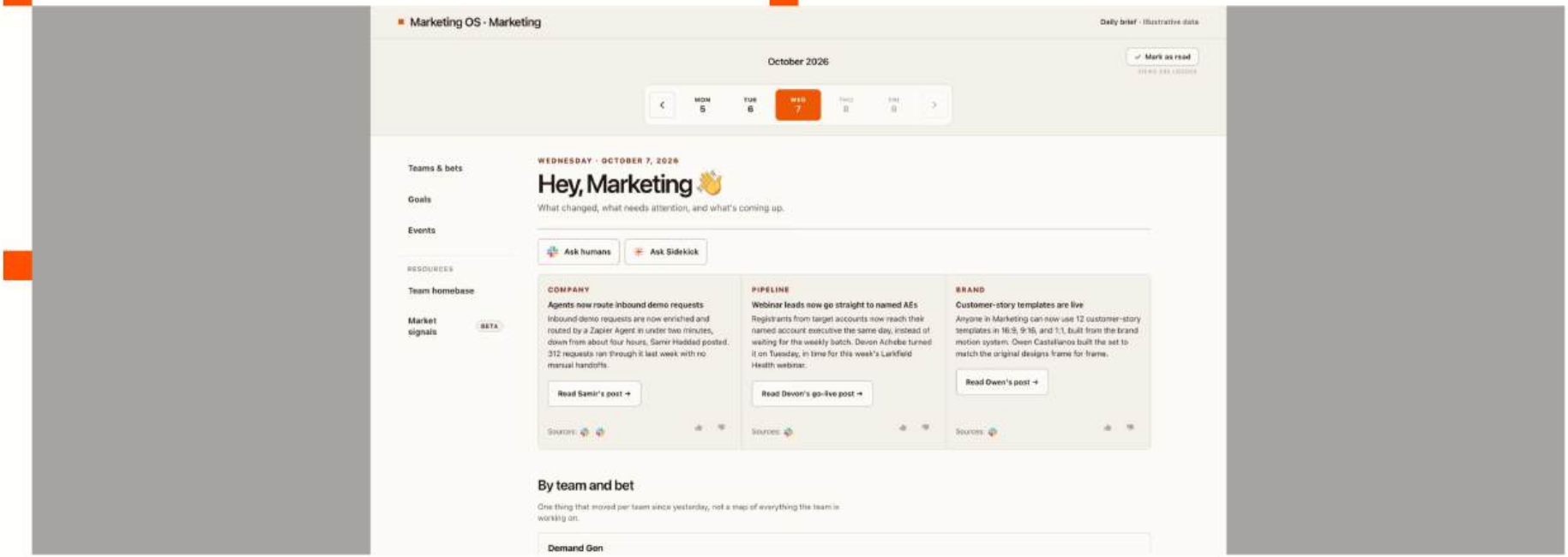
Live via MCP

→ Daily Brief
→ Battle cards
→ Sales decks
→ Deal records
→ Every agent, instantly

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MARKETINGOS

MarketingOS in practice



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MARKETINGOS

Good morning, Marketing



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MARKETINGOS

Finds hidden gold

REACH

registrations

8K

VALUE

in ad credits

$137K

SPEED

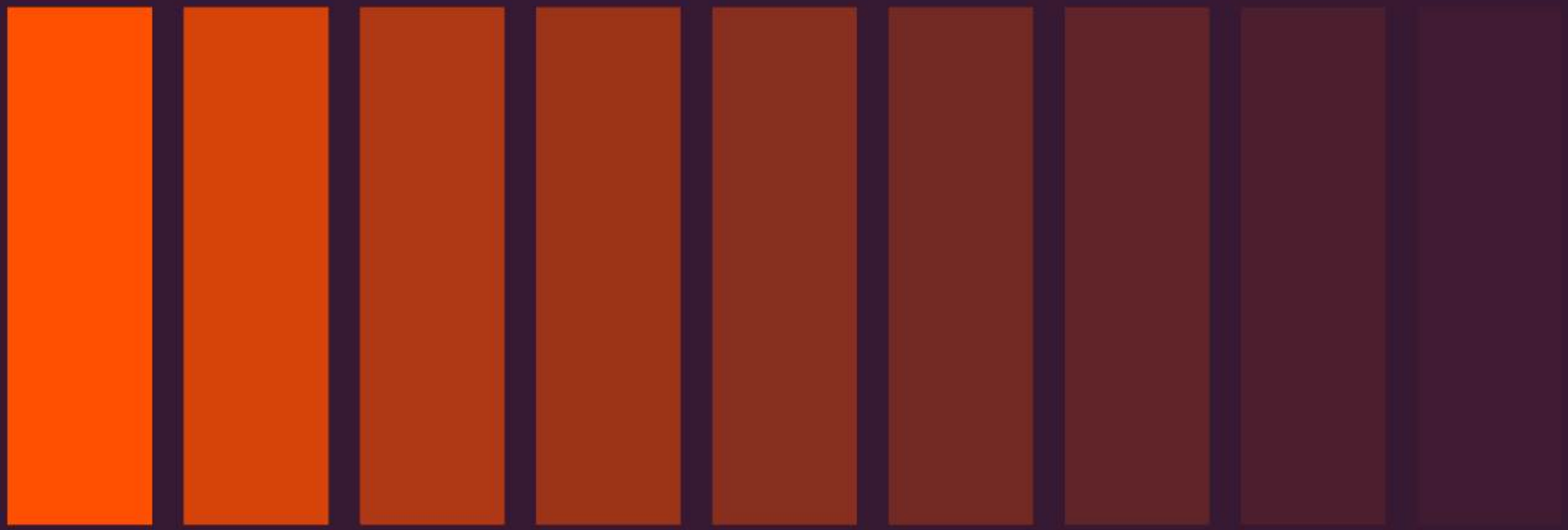
sales activity turnaround

Same day

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MARKETINGOS

Lossless marketing



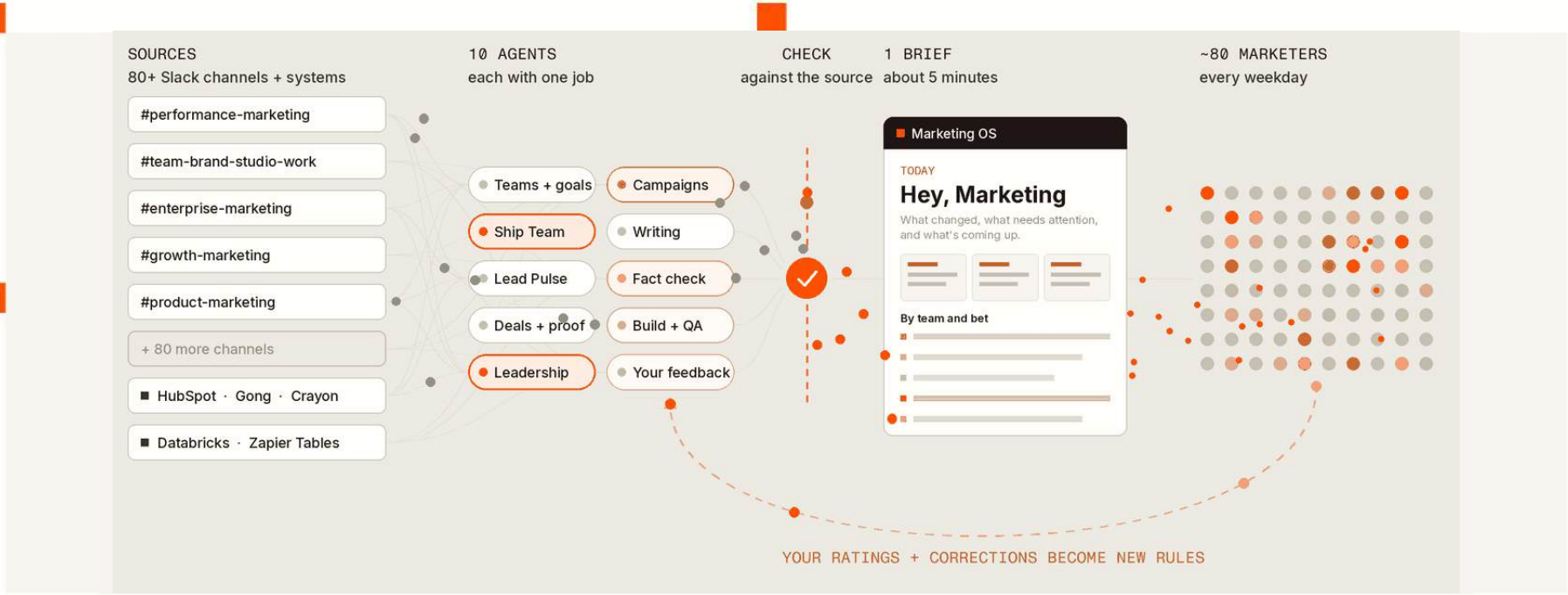
MASTER

NINTH COPY

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AGENTS

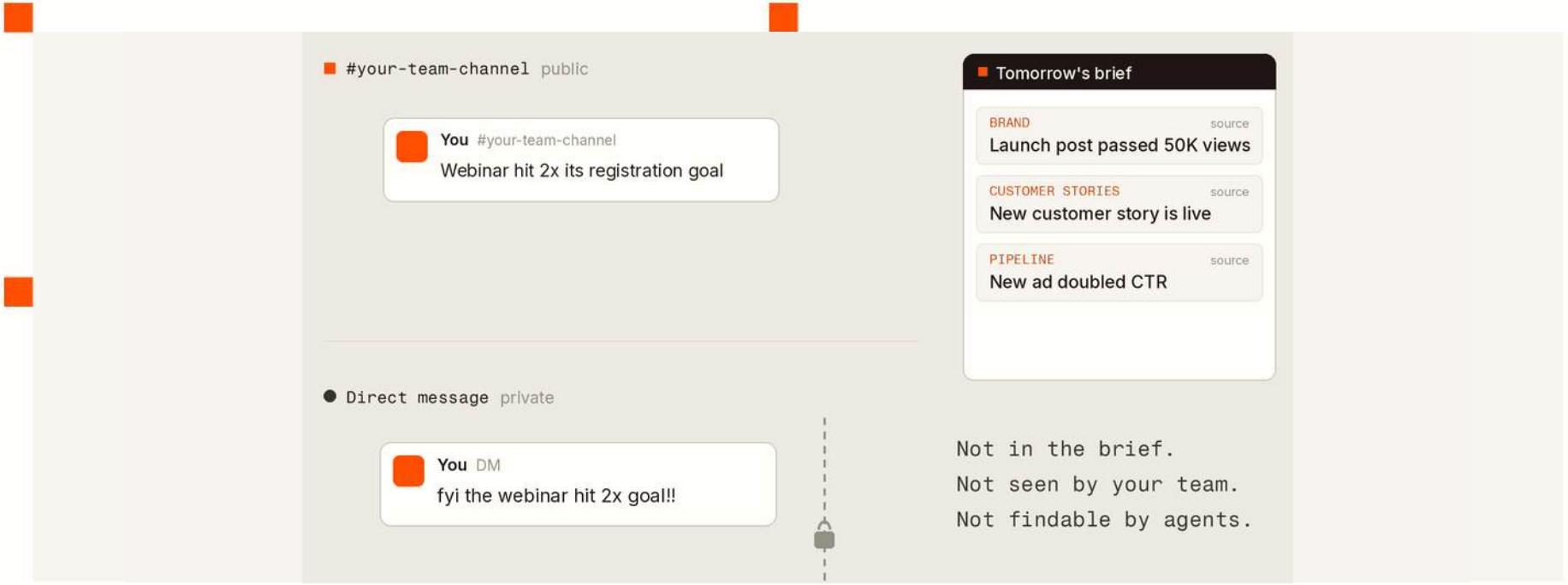
Ten agents. 80+ channels. Every morning.



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AGENTS

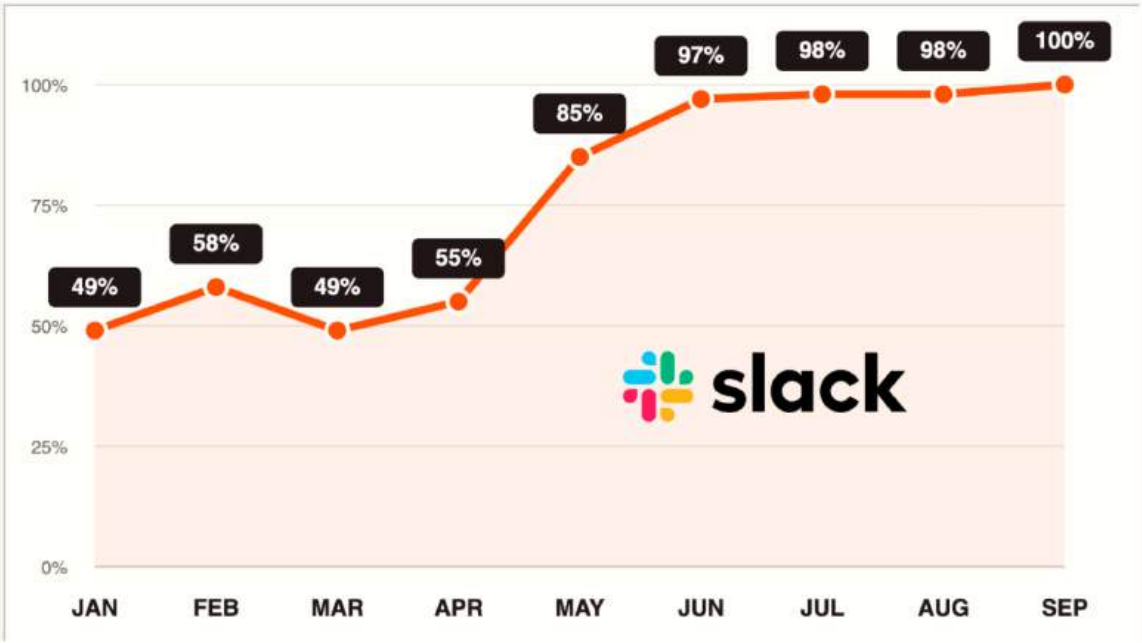
Work in public



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AGENTS

Adoption, Jan–Sep



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SECTION 04

Builds by marketers



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MARKETER BUILDS

Event Speaker Management System

Cursor · Zapier MCP · Figma



Donna Fung She/Her · 1st

Senior Brand Designer @ Zapier

Toronto, Ontario, Canada · **Contact info**

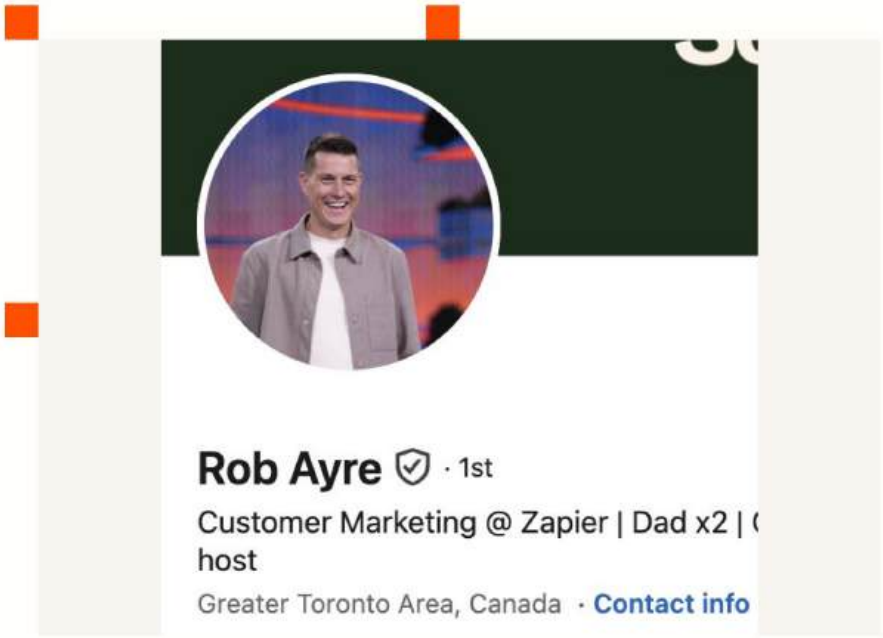


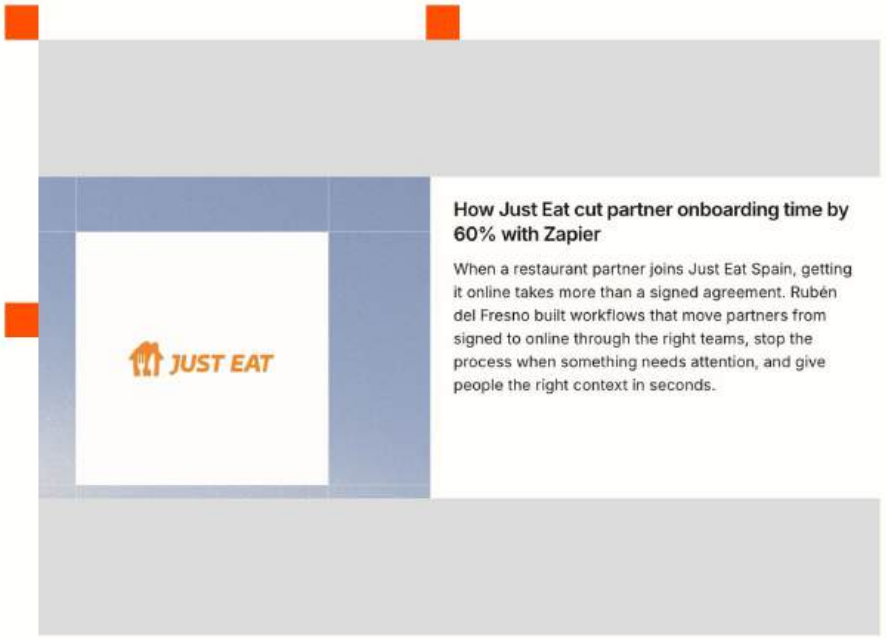
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MARKETER BUILDS

Customer Story Creator

Okta · Toyota · Palo Alto Networks · Netflix · Crunchbase

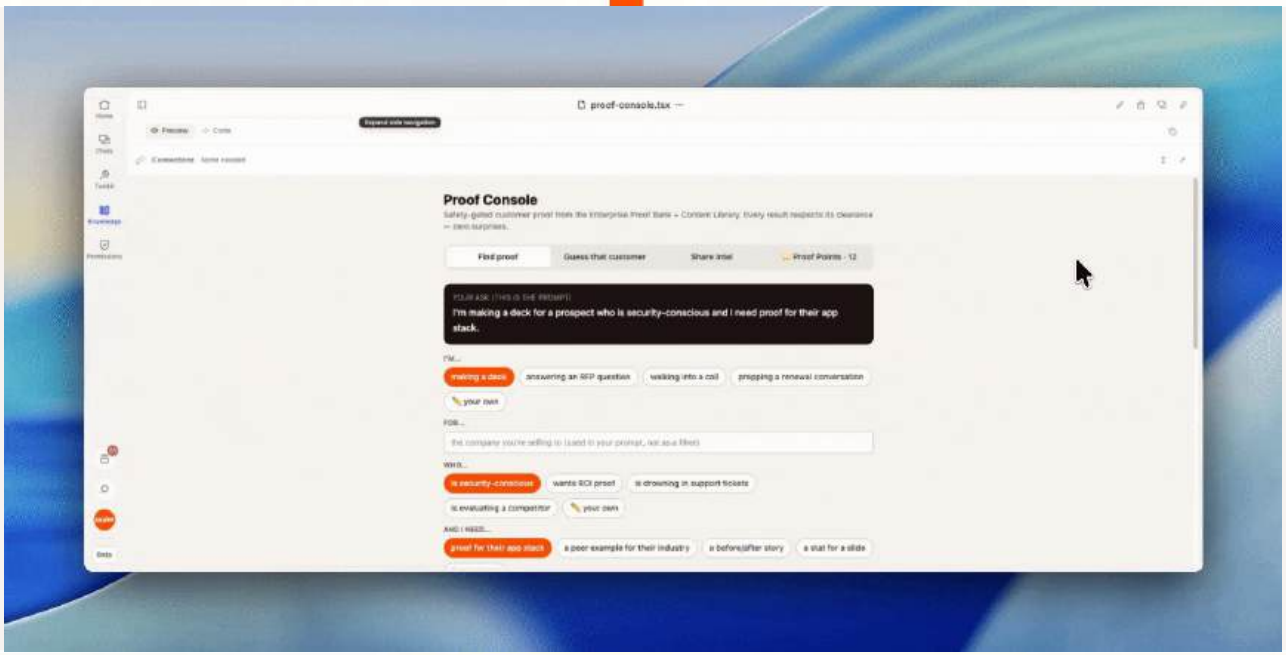




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MARKETER BUILDS

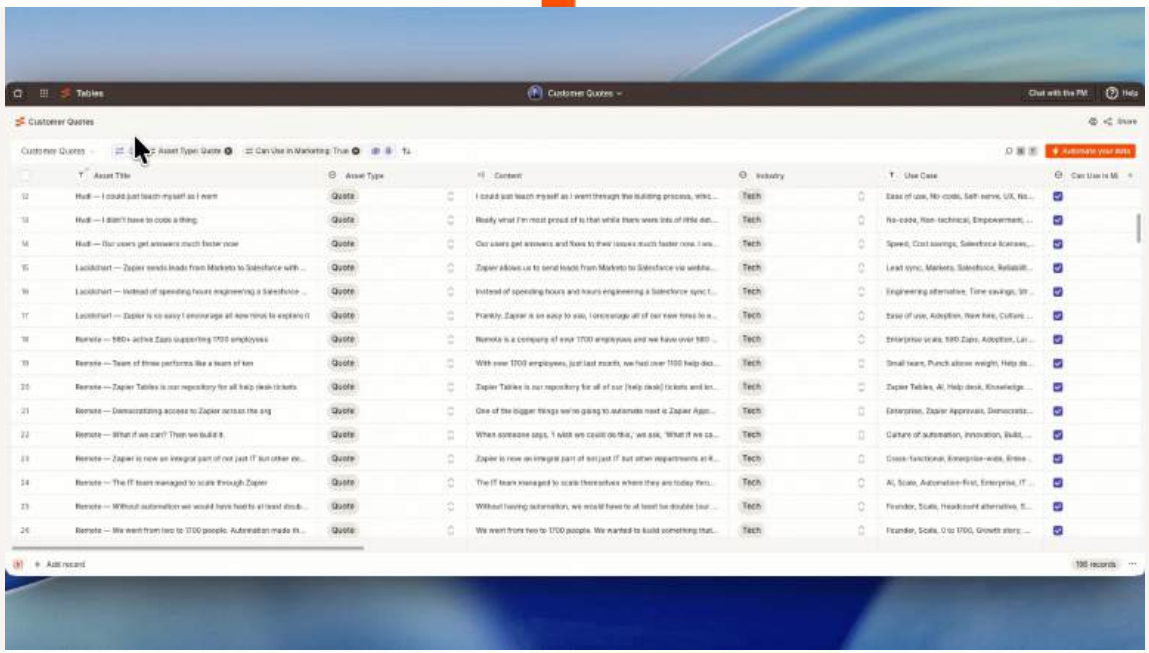
Customer Story Creator



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MARKETER BUILDS

Customer Story Creator



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MARKETER BUILDS

ROI system to manage 150+ creators / influencers

$1M

in savings

3x

budget increase



Matt Brown · 1st

2x Unicorn Growth Leader | PLG + SLG Marketing

Chicago, Illinois, United States · **Contact info**

14,584 followers · **500+ connections**

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MARKETER BUILDS

Influencer program ROI dashboard & leaderboard



Influencer Leaderboard

Rank	Influencer	Clicks	Signups
01	Alex Morgan	24,850	1,240
02	Jordan Lee	21,320	1,065
03	Taylor Brooks	18,740	938
04	Casey Rivera	15,600	780
05	Sam Parker	12,480	624

Illustrative data • Ranked by signups

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MARKETER BUILDS

The paid social GTM

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MEASURING AIT

How am I measuring AIT?

"Q1 – Q3 largest *pipeline* quarters in history."

"Marketing is executing at a materially *higher level* than it has in years."

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PATH TO WIN

Path to win

Q1 · RED ALERT #1

Q1

Expectation setting

Q2 · BUILDING

Q2

Hitting pipeline

Q3 · EXPANDING

Q3

Hitting sales goals

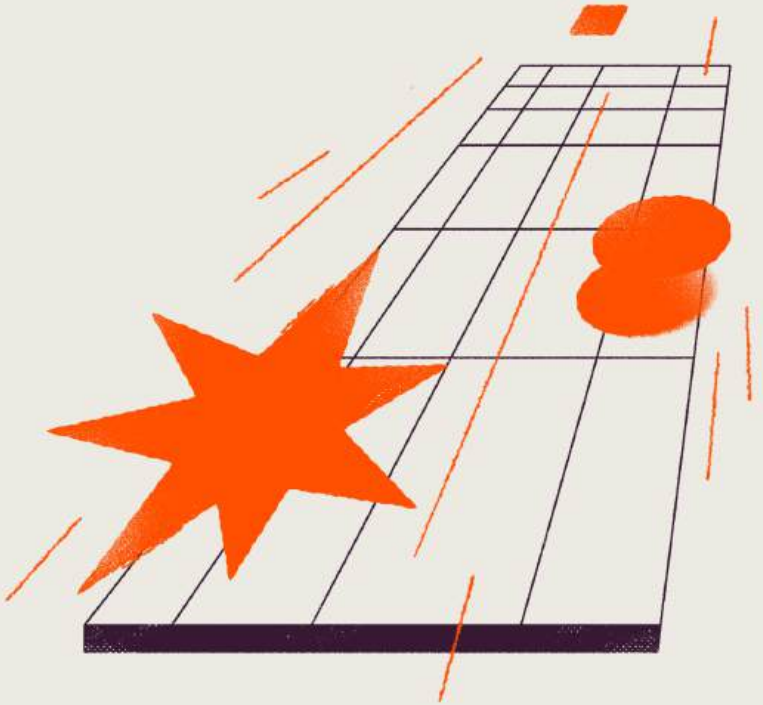
Q4 · WE'RE IN CONTROL

Q4

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SECTION 05

Next Red Alert



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NEXT RED ALERT

Agentic is a complete overhaul of the way you work

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NEXT RED ALERT

Flatten org and get ready for extreme pushback

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NEXT RED ALERT

Winners are flexible, urgent, multi-disciplined, resilient, systems thinkers

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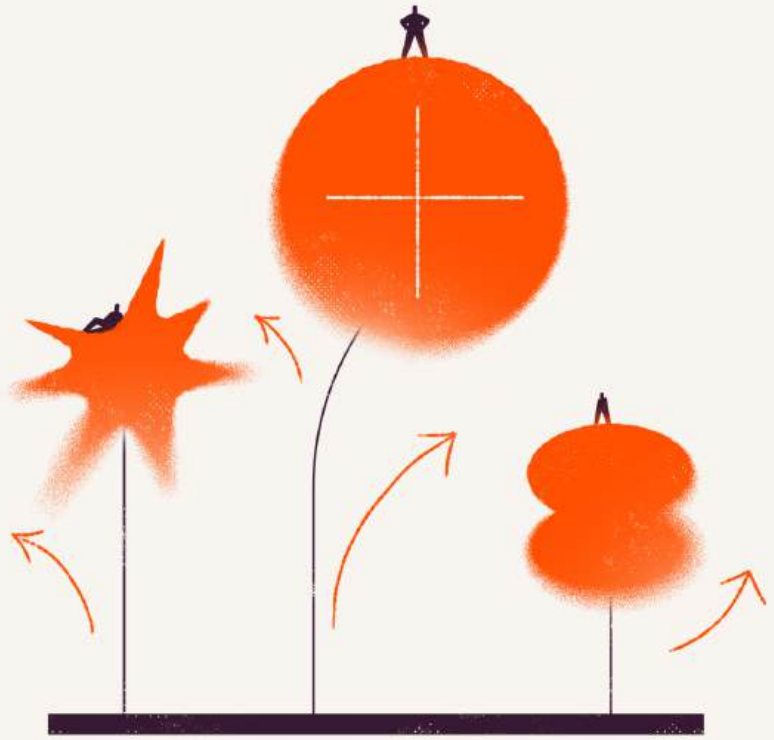
NEXT RED ALERT

Pay marketers their money

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Change the way you work.

Don't wait for a Red Alert, call your own NOW.



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MAICON FORWARD

DAN SLAGEN

CMO & CAITO

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THANK YOU! WE APPRECIATE YOUR SESSION FEEDBACK.

#MAICON26